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Democracy Dies in Darkness

TUESDAY, MAY 27, 2025 • \$4

Details of E. coli surge not disclosed

Critics say Trump's anti-regulatory push threatens food safety

BY STEPHANIE ARMOUR

Colton George felt sick. The 9-year-old Indiana boy told his parents his stomach hurt. He kept running to the bathroom and felt too ill to finish a basketball game.

Days later, he lay in a hospital bed, fighting for his life. He had eaten tainted salad, according to a lawsuit against the lettuce grower filed by his parents on April 17 in federal court for the Southern District of Indiana.

The *E. coli* bacteria that ravaged Colton's kidneys was a genetic match to the strain that killed one person and sickened nearly 90 people in 15 states last fall. Federal health agencies investigated the cases and linked them to a farm that grew romaine lettuce.

But most people have never heard about this outbreak, which a Feb. 11 internal Food and Drug Administration memo linked to a single lettuce processor and ranch as the source of the contamination. In what many experts said was a break with common practice, officials never issued public communications after the investigation or identified the grower who produced the lettuce.

From failing to publicize a major outbreak to scaling back safety alert specialists and rules, the Trump administration's anti-regulatory and cost-cutting push risks unraveling a critical system that helps ensure the safety of the U.S. food supply, according to consumer advocates, researchers and former employees at the FDA and U.S. Department of Agriculture.

The investigation into the illnesses began near the end of the Biden administration, but work on the lettuce outbreak wasn't completed until Feb. 11. At that time, the decision was made by the Trump administration not to

SEE SAFETY ON A11

Crossroads: Bill's plans for energy money frustrate GOP senators. A10

Solemn reflection on Memorial Day



MATT MCCLAIN/THE WASHINGTON POST

Gulf War veteran John Schoon visits the Vietnam Veterans Memorial on the National Mall on Monday. At Arlington National Cemetery, President Donald Trump honored fallen service members. In D.C., rock star Gene Simmons paid tribute to a man who helped liberate his mother at the end of World War II. **Stories, A16 and B1**

CHARLES B. RANGEL 1930-2025

Congressman was a powerful voice for Harlem

BY EDWARD WALSH

Charles B. Rangel, a gravelly voiced and exuberant congressman from the Harlem neighborhood of New York who became the first African American chairman of the House Ways and Means Committee but was forced to relinquish that coveted position because of financial transgressions, died May 26 at a hospital in Manhattan. He was 94.

His death was confirmed in a statement provided by the City College of New York, where he had served as statesman-in-residence. The cause was not immediately available.

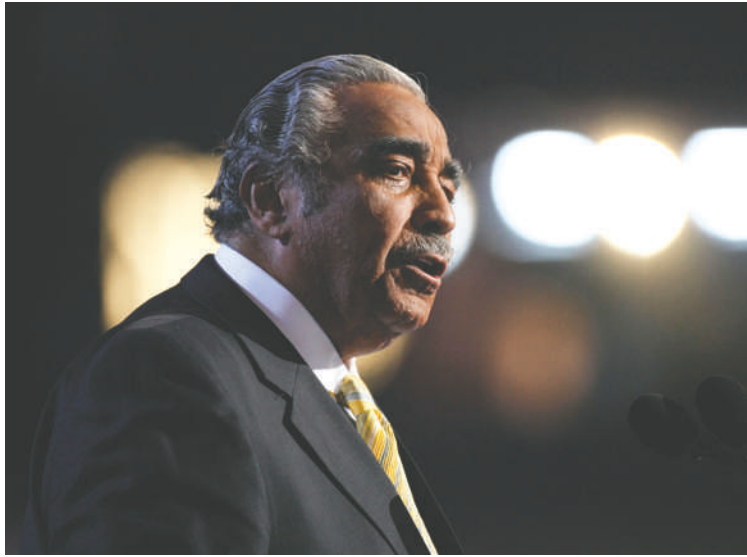
Mr. Rangel was an outspoken liberal Democrat during his 46-year congressional career, which ended in 2017 when he decided not to seek a 24th term in an

increasingly Latino district that came to include Upper Manhattan and parts of the Bronx. His successor, Adriano Espaillat, became the first Dominican American member of Congress.

In the House, Mr. Rangel championed programs to aid the poor; supported higher taxes on the wealthy; opposed interventionist military policies, including the 2003 invasion of Iraq; and worked against the 1996 welfare reform legislation that was signed into law by President Bill Clinton, a fellow Democrat.

He could be caustic in public, but behind the scenes, the gregarious and genial Mr. Rangel, widely known as "Charlie," was a popular figure on Capitol Hill, with friends in both parties. He was considered a shrewd and deft legislative

SEE RANGEL ON A4



JUSTIN SULLIVAN/GETTY IMAGES

Charles B. Rangel, who was the first Black House Ways and Means chair, relinquished that post because of financial transgressions.

Democrats' struggles revive the debate over word choice

They look for vocabulary to present themselves as inclusive, but not elitist

BY NAFTALI BENDAVID

Maybe it's using the word "oligarchs" instead of rich people. Or referring to "people experiencing food insecurity" rather than Americans going hungry. Or "equity" in place of "equality," or "justice-involved populations" instead of prisoners.

As Democrats wrestle with who to be in the era of President Donald Trump, an increasing number of party members — especially centrists — are reviving the argument that Democrats need to rethink the words they use to talk with the voters whose trust they need to regain.

They contend that liberal candidates too often use language from elite, highly educated circles that suggests the speakers consider themselves smart and

virtuous, while casting implied judgment on those who speak more plainly — hardly a formula for winning people over, they say.

The latest debate is, in part, also a proxy for the bigger battle over what the Democrats' identity should be in the aftermath of November's devastating losses — especially as the party searches for ways to reverse its overwhelming rejection by rural and White working-class voters.

"Some words are just too Ivy League-tested terms," said Sen. Ruben Gallego (D-Arizona). "I'm going to piss some people off by saying this, but 'social equity' — why do we say that? Why don't we say, 'We want you to have an even chance?'"

Kentucky Gov. Andy Beshear — who, like Gallego, is considering a potential 2028 Democratic presidential hopeful — made a similar point.

"I believe that, over time, and probably for well-meaning reasons, Democrats have begun to speak like professors and started using advocacy-speak that was

SEE DEMOCRATS ON A2

Gaza under fire as aid group says it has begun food delivery

Israeli airstrikes destroy a school being used as a shelter, with a witness reporting at least 30 fatalities



KHAMES ALREFI/ANADOLU/GETTY IMAGES

Verd al-Sheikh Khalil, 7, who survived an Israeli airstrike on a Gaza school that was being used as a shelter, with her father on Monday. Her mother and five siblings were killed in the attack.

BY SHIRA RUBIN, ABIE CHEESEMAN AND KAREN DEYOUNG

TEL AVIV — Deadly Israeli airstrikes hit a school turned shelter and other targets in Gaza on Monday, according to rescue workers and witnesses, as a controversial new private aid organization with ties to both the Israeli and U.S. governments said it began distributing food inside the enclave.

Faris Afana, an ambulance driver in Gaza who was at the scene of the strike, said that civil defense crews demolished walls to reach victims trapped under burning debris. He said he counted at least 30 fatalities and that, with many more suffering severe burns, he expected the death toll to rise.

"The school is very large and shelters thousands of displaced people; even the courtyards and playgrounds are filled with tents," Afana said. He said the school "showed no signs of any armed presence."

The strikes killed at least 25 people, according to Zaher al-

SEE GAZA ON A8

IN THE NEWS

Vaccine access The FDA's plan to restrict approval for coronavirus shots raised concern among some who won't be eligible. A3

A Kennedy Center quandary Broadway shows are cash cows for the D.C. arts institution, but Trump's takeover may keep producers away. C1

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Two Native American tribes sued the government over its role in boarding schools. A3

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SPORTS Trevor Williams's J.R.R. Tolkien book club has helped his Washington Nationals teammates build fellowship in pursuit of a ring. D1

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